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ECOMMERCE PLAYBOOK

The Shopify Store Launch Bible

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The Shopify Store Launch Bible

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Chapter 1 - The launch mindset (read this first)

What "launch" actually means

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The 80/20 of launching

```
80% of launch success = product choice + trust signals + traffic
20% = theme design, apps, fancy features


A basic Dawn theme with great products and real reviews beats a custom-designed store
with blurry supplier photos every time.

### India-specific reality check

- **COD is not optional** for most Indian categories - 40-60% of orders are COD
depending on category
- **RTO (return to origin)** will eat 15-30% of COD orders initially - budget for it
- **WhatsApp is your sales channel** - order updates, tracking, support all happen there
- **Trust signals matter more** - Indian buyers check ratings, reviews and "is this
legit" harder than US buyers

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## Chapter 2 - Pre-launch: the 7 decisions before you touch Shopify

Do NOT sign up for Shopify until these are answered:

### 1. What are you selling?

Not "ecommerce products" - a specific product or tight category. "Phone accessories for
Android users" beats "gadgets". Focus wins.

### 2. Who is buying it?

Age, city/tier, income, where they hang out online, what problem your product solves for
them. Write it down in one paragraph.

### 3. What's your price range?

Impulse ( ¹199-499), mid ( ¹500-1999), premium ( ¹2000+). Your price decides your photography,
your ad channel and your margin math.

### 4. Where will traffic come from?
```

Pick ONE primary channel for launch: Instagram reels, WhatsApp status, Facebook ads, or SEO content. You can add channels later - you cannot do all at once.

5. Can you fulfil orders?

Dropshipping supplier lead time? Your own stock? Pre-orders? Know the real delivery window - it goes on your product pages and in customer messages.

6. What's your margin after everything?

```
Real margin = Price - Product cost - Shipping - Payment fees - Returns/RTO reserve
```

If real margin is under 25%, your pricing or product choice needs work before launch.

7. What makes you trustworthy?

GST number, business address, return policy, real photos, WhatsApp number, response time. Collect these BEFORE launch - adding them after is painful.

Chapter 3 - Store setup: the 5 essentials (skip everything else)

1. Theme: Dawn or a Dawn-child

Free, fast, supported forever. Customize colors/fonts to your brand. Do NOT buy a ¹15,000 theme on day 1 - you don't know what you need yet.

2. Payments: Razorpay + COD

- Razorpay for UPI/cards/netbanking (instant activation for most Indian businesses)
- COD for categories where it's expected (fashion, home, general merchandise)
- Test both with a real ¹1 transaction before launch

3. Shipping: one courier to start

Delhivery, Bluedart or Shiprocket aggregator. Shiprocket is easiest for multi-courier rate comparison. Set realistic delivery promises - under-promise, over-deliver.

4. WhatsApp Business app

Free, on your phone. Set up: business name, catalogue, quick replies ("Where is my order?", "Return policy"), greeting message. This is your command center.

5. Policies: 4 pages that build trust

- Refund/return policy (7-15 days, clear conditions)
- Shipping policy (timeframes, charges)
- Privacy policy (required for payment gateways)
- Contact page with real WhatsApp number + email + address

Everything else - loyalty apps, popups, chat widgets, fancy countdown timers - comes AFTER first sales.

Chapter 4 - Products: the listing that actually sells

Product selection for launch

- Start with 5-15 products max - a focused store beats a 500-product mess
- Choose products you can photograph or that have decent supplier images
- Verify supplier reliability BEFORE listing (order a sample to yourself - always)

The listing formula

```
Title: [Brand] [Product type] [key spec] [use case]
Photos: 5-8 images - hero shot, angles, detail macro, size reference, lifestyle
Price: psychological ( ¹499 not ¹500) with real margin
Bullets: 5 benefit-led points (see the Product Listing Copy Bible approach)
Description: problem !’ solution !’ specs !’ FAQ
```

Photos: the #1 conversion factor

- Supplier images are usually terrible - watermarked, cluttered, low-res
- Minimum viable: clean white-background shots. AI photoshoot tools or a ¹500 photo setup (white sheet + daylight) works
- Video: 10-second product video on hero products lifts conversion noticeably

Pricing your first products

```
Price = (Product cost + Shipping + Fees) / (1 - Target margin)
Example:  ¹300 product +  ¹80 shipping + 2% fees, 40% margin target
Price = (300 + 80 + ~10) / 0.6 "H  ¹650 !’ round to  ¹649 or  ¹699
```

Chapter 5 - The launch traffic plan (week by week)

Week -1: Tease

- Announce on WhatsApp status, Instagram, personal network
- "Something new launching this week" - collect interest
- Finalize products, test checkout end-to-end

Week 0: Launch day

- Email/WhatsApp broadcast to every contact you have
- Instagram: launch reel + stories + feed post
- Offer: launch discount or free shipping - real, time-bound
- Be online all day - answer every WhatsApp message fast

Week 1: Momentum

- Post daily: product spotlights, unboxing, behind-scenes
- WhatsApp status: new products, offers, packing orders
- Reply to EVERY comment and DM within an hour
- First 10 orders: personally thank each customer, ask for review/photo

Week 2-4: Optimize

- Check: which products get views but no sales? (price/photo/listing problem)
- Which products sell without promotion? (double down - ads, bundles)
- Fix the leaks: slow pages, broken links, unanswered messages

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Chapter 6 - Fulfilment: don't let operations kill you

The daily routine

- Morning: check orders, print shipping labels, hand to courier
- Throughout day: WhatsApp replies (order updates, tracking, support)
- Evening: confirm dispatches, update customers

WhatsApp order flow (the Indian standard)

```
Order placed !’ "Thanks! Order #[X] confirmed. We'll ship within 24h."
Shipped !’ "Your order is on the way! Track: [link]. Delivery in 3-5 days."
Out for delivery !’ optional but loved
Delivered !’ "Delivered! How's [product]? Reply with feedback - we'd love a review."
```

Automate with Shopify WhatsApp apps or do it manually at first - either way, customers expect updates.

RTO management (COD reality)

- Confirm COD orders via WhatsApp/call before dispatch for high-value orders (> ¹1000)
- Address verification matters - incomplete addresses = RTO
- Expect 15-30% RTO initially; it drops as you build trust and repeat buyers

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Chapter 7 - First 90 days: from launch to real business

Days 1-30: survive and learn

- Goal: 10-50 orders, learn what sells, fix basics
- Do NOT add new products constantly - optimize what you have
- Collect every piece of feedback

Days 31-60: double what works

- Pick your top 2-3 products by sales + margin
- Improve their listings (photos, copy, price tests)
- Start simple ads on proven winners only (¹300-500/day Meta ads test)
- Email/WhatsApp your first customers: "new arrivals + 10% off"

Days 61-90: systemize

- Bundle your bestsellers (raises order value)
- Ask every happy customer for review/photo - build social proof
- Document your supplier lead times, best courier, top products
- Plan next quarter: more products? new channel? hire help?

Chapter 8 - The launch checklist (print this)

PRE-LAUNCH
[ ] Products chosen (5-15, focused category)
[ ] Supplier sample ordered and tested
[ ] Shopify store live with Dawn theme customized
[ ] Razorpay activated + tested with real payment
[ ] COD enabled (if category needs it)
[ ] Shipping courier set up + rates tested
[ ] WhatsApp Business set up with catalogue
[ ] Policies published (refund, shipping, privacy, contact)
[ ] Product photos ready (5+ per product, clean)
[ ] Prices set with real margin math
[ ] Checkout tested end-to-end (all payment methods)
[ ] Order notification emails working

LAUNCH WEEK
[ ] WhatsApp status announcement
[ ] Instagram launch content posted
[ ] Personal network informed
[ ] Launch offer live (discount/free shipping)
[ ] Online all day for customer messages
[ ] First orders personally thanked

POST-LAUNCH
[ ] Daily WhatsApp order updates going out
[ ] Reviews requested from happy customers
[ ] Weekly sales review (what sells, what's stuck)
[ ] Winning products identified for ads

Chapter 9 - Common launch mistakes (and the fix)

Mistake	Why it kills you	Fix
500 products on day 1	Nothing stands out, photos are bad, support drowns	Launch with 5-15 focused products
No COD when customers expect it	Lost 40-60% of orders	Enable COD for relevant categories
Supplier images unedited	Looks fake/untrustworthy	Clean photos minimum, AI photoshoot better
No WhatsApp updates	Customers panic, chargebacks, bad reviews	Automate order status messages
Ads before organic proof	Paying to send traffic to unproven store	Get 10-20 organic orders first
Fake urgency everywhere	Countdown timers that reset = distrust	Real deadlines only
No return policy clarity	Disputes, bad reviews, payment gateway issues	Clear published policy
Underpricing for "traction"	Margin death, can't afford ads	Price for 35-50% real margin

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Chapter 10 - Your first 90 days scoreboard

Track weekly:

- Orders count
- Revenue
- Top 3 products by units
- Return/RTO rate
- WhatsApp response time
- Review count

By day 90 you should know: what sells, what margin you actually make, which channel brings buyers, and whether this is a business or a hobby. Both answers are fine - but now you'll know which.

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